

Identifying characters

Alternating between different forms of speech makes a narrative more interesting to read. When converting direct speech (first person) to indirect speech (third person), it's important to take into account who is speaking, and to whom, and to change the relevant nouns and pronouns to match.

The doctor is talking to his patient, whom the context has identified as Peter.

The doctor said, "I fear that you have gamer's thumb."

In direct speech, the speaker is usually identified.

The direct speech has been converted to indirect speech, but it now sounds as though the doctor is the sufferer.

The doctor said he fears that he has gamer's thumb. ❌

In most cases, it is possible to find out whether a character is male or female by looking at the surrounding text.

This is still in the present tense; indirect speech is usually written in the past tense.

The doctor said he feared that Peter had gamer's thumb. ✅

It is now clear who is speaking to whom, and the indirect speech is in the past tense.

Time and space

If direct speech is being recounted (turned into indirect speech) in a different place and at a different time from where and when it happened, the adverbs and adverb phrases used must match the new situation. For example, the direct speech "Go to the hospital today!" would be recounted a week later in the following way: He was told to go to the hospital that day.

Direct speech	Indirect speech
now	then
here	there
this (morning)	that (morning)
next (week)	the following (week)
today	that day
tomorrow	the next day/the following day
yesterday	the previous day/the day before

Varying verbs

The most common verbs used to report speech are *said*, *told*, and *asked*. Indirect speech can be made more interesting if the writer uses a variety of reporting verbs. The verbs used in the simple clauses that indicate who said what in direct speech can be varied in the same way.

▷ Descriptive direct speech

The verb *sobbed* encourages the reader to sympathize with Peter. *Said* would not have this effect.

▷ Interesting indirect speech

Use unusual verbs such as *promised* and *begged* to add emotion to indirect speech.

• Indirect speech often uses the words *said*, *asked*, or *told*, but don't confuse it with *direct speech*, which is always in quotation marks.

"I feel like a freak!" **sobbed** Peter.

The doctor **promised** that Peter's symptoms were curable. Peter **begged** him to help.